
Caesurae and Continuities: A Qualitative-Quantitative Analysis of a Correspondence Network between 1882–1926

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Abstract

Letters from the late 19th and early 20th century offer a uniquely rich, semi-standardized foundation of sources that can be systematically transformed into research data. This lecture presents results from an ongoing history dissertation at the University of Innsbruck. Based on an inherited correspondence corpus of approximately 9,000 sources, an extensive network around the married couple Herma and Rudolf von Unterrichter as it's key nodes is formed, spanning from 1882–1926 and peaking during the First World War. The lecture intends to introduce a dataset strictly following FAIR principles and by that discussing issues of data integrity and historical data criticism as shown by Fickers and Tatarinov (2022).

The research combines methods of qualitative discourse analysis – done by MAXQDA – with quantitative network analysis implemented in Nodegoat and R to quantify social interaction patterns with centrality measures. The dissertation and lecture intend to answer the question: how did the habitual behaviours of Herma and Rudolf evolve – through war – across imperial and post-imperial contexts? By drawing on Pierre Bourdieu's theory of habitus (Bourdieu 1992, 63), Mark Granovetter's assumptions concerning "weak" and "strong" ties (Granovetter 1983, 201–33) and rational choice frameworks, micro-level routines are combined with macro-level structures, tracing the entanglement of individuals and collectives (Raub 2025, 336). Findings illuminate how imperial biographies were reconfigured after 1918 and how, in Pieter Judson's sense, also relationships and durable networks sustained elements of imperial continuity in the Austro-Hungarian successor states (Judson 2017, 18). By demonstrating the heuristic value of network methodologies against the background of upheavals and long-term continuities, the lecture presents correspondence-based datasets as an important part for understanding social transformation in Central Europe following the dissolution of the Habsburg Monarchy. More broadly, it argues for reproducible, interoperable workflows that bridge historically grounded qualitative interpretation and quantitative modelling.

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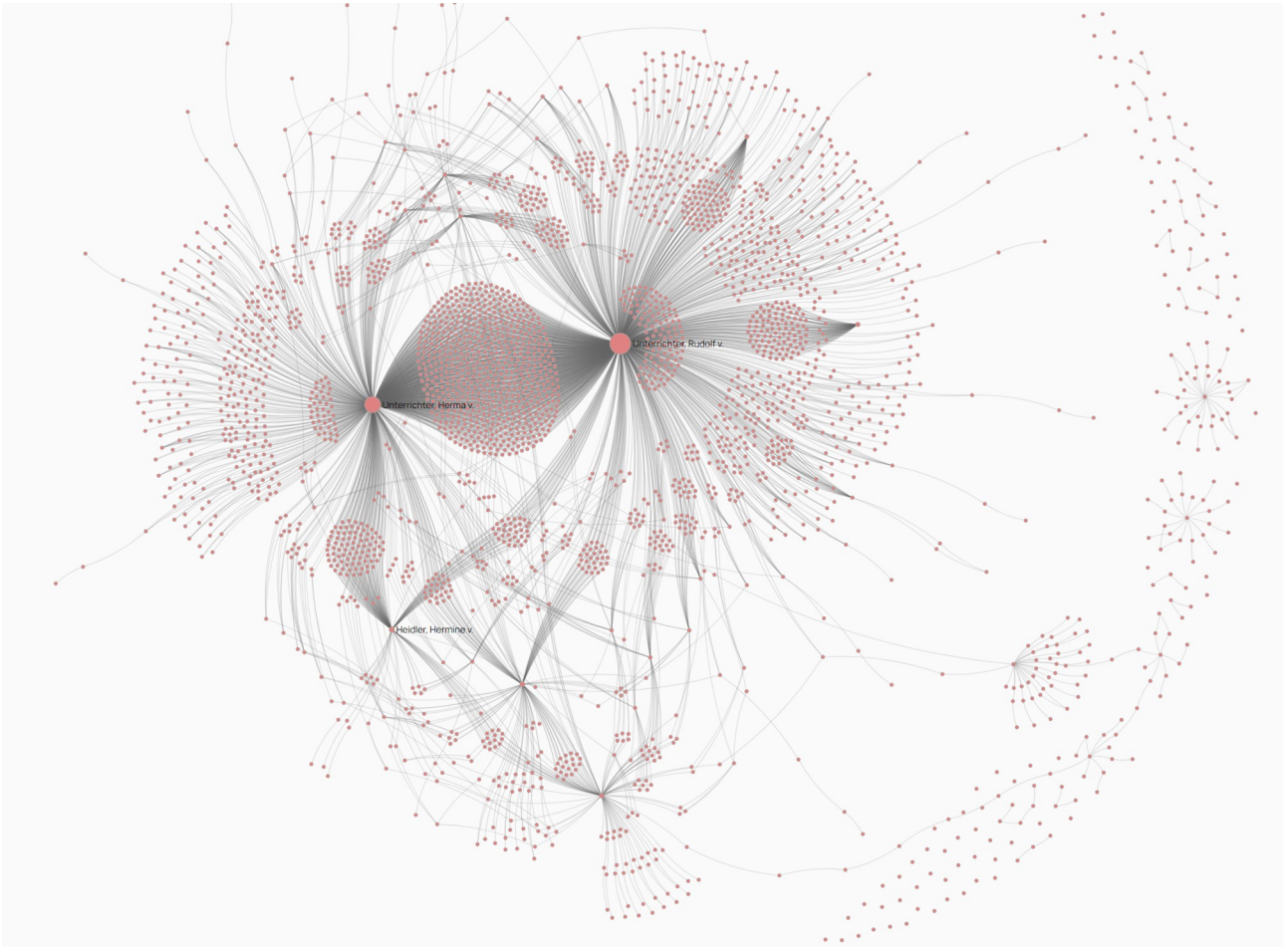


Figure 1. Visualization of the Network of Herma and Rudolf von Unterrichter with the Software Nodegoat.